idolatrous. They pointed to many passages in the Bible, most notably the Second Commandment, that forbade making any graven images. While Christian churches traditionally interpreted the Second Commandment in a way that allowed the veneration of icons, emperors like Constantine V argued that this was a mistake and that disasters like Christian defeats by the armies of Islam were due to God's wrath over the worship of icons. In 754 more than three hundred bishops assembled in the Council of Hieria to support Constantine's iconoclastic position.

Compared with Stalin's collectivisation campaign, this was a minor reform. Families and villages were required to give up their icons, but not their private property or their children. Yet Byzantine iconoclasm met with widespread resistance. Unlike the participants in the Council of Hieria, many ordinary priests, monks and believers were deeply attached to their icons. The resulting struggle ripped apart Byzantine society until the emperors conceded defeat and reversed course.[105] Constantine V was later vilified by Byzantine historians as 'Constantine the Shitty' (Koprónimos), and a story was spread about him that he defecated during his baptism.[106]

Unlike pre-modern churches, which developed slowly over many centuries and therefore tended to be conservative and suspicious of rapid changes, modern totalitarian parties like the Nazi Party and the Soviet Communist Party were organised within a single generation around the promise to quickly revolutionise society. They didn't have centuries-old traditions and structures to defend. When their leaders conceived some ambitious plan to smash existing traditions and structures, party members typically fell in line.

Perhaps most important of all, pre-modern churches could not become tools of totalitarian control because they themselves suffered from the same limitations as all other pre-modern organisations. While they had local agents everywhere, in the shape of parish priests, monks and itinerant preachers, the difficulty of transmitting and processing information meant that church leaders knew little about what was going on in remote communities, and local priests had a large degree of autonomy. Consequently, churches tended to be local affairs. People in every province and village often venerated local saints, upheld local traditions, performed local rites and might even have had local doctrinal ideas that differed from the official line.[107] If the pope in Rome wanted to do something about an independent-minded priest in a remote Polish parish, he had to send a letter